

Fund Schools for Reality: **A Parliamentary Debate** **on Sustainable School** **Funding**



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This report summarises findings from a national survey of school staff and leaders on the sustainability and fairness of current school funding arrangements. The evidence presented supports a formal petition calling for a parliamentary debate on reforming school funding.

1. Executive Summary and Context

Schools are facing increasing financial pressure at a time when their responsibilities have expanded significantly. This survey explored awareness of forecast real-terms funding reductions, views on per-pupil funding, expectations placed on schools beyond teaching, and support for funding reform. Across responses, there is a clear professional consensus: current funding arrangements do not reflect the reality of running a school and are undermining sustainability.

2. Findings from Binary Survey Questions

Awareness of the forecast 4.9% real-terms reduction in per-pupil funding by 2028/29 was mixed. However, once informed, respondents overwhelmingly expressed concern. The per-pupil funding model was widely rejected as the sole basis for school budgets. Most respondents supported funding models based on real operating costs, recognising that staffing, buildings, energy, IT, and safeguarding costs do not reduce in line with pupil numbers. There was strong agreement that schools now provide extensive support beyond teaching, including mental health support, safeguarding, food provision, and family guidance. Respondents believe these roles require dedicated funding rather than being absorbed into already stretched teaching budgets.

3. Mandate for Parliamentary Debate

Support for reform was exceptionally strong. The majority of respondents stated that they would support a call to government to reform school funding and would add their name to a petition. This represents a clear mandate for Parliament to debate whether current funding arrangements are fit for purpose and how a sustainable, needs-based model could be implemented. The petition calls for a debate focusing on real-terms funding erosion, the limitations of per-pupil funding, and the need to properly resource schools for their expanded role in society.



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Appendix A: Five Key Issues from Narrative Question 1 Fair and Realistic School Funding

1. SEND funding is inadequate, delayed, and misaligned with the level of need in mainstream schools.
2. Teacher capacity and workload are unsustainable given current expectations.
3. Support staff, including teaching assistants, are underfunded and underpaid despite their critical role.
4. School funding does not reflect real operating costs such as buildings, energy, IT, and maintenance.
5. Schools are absorbing responsibilities previously held by other public services without dedicated funding.

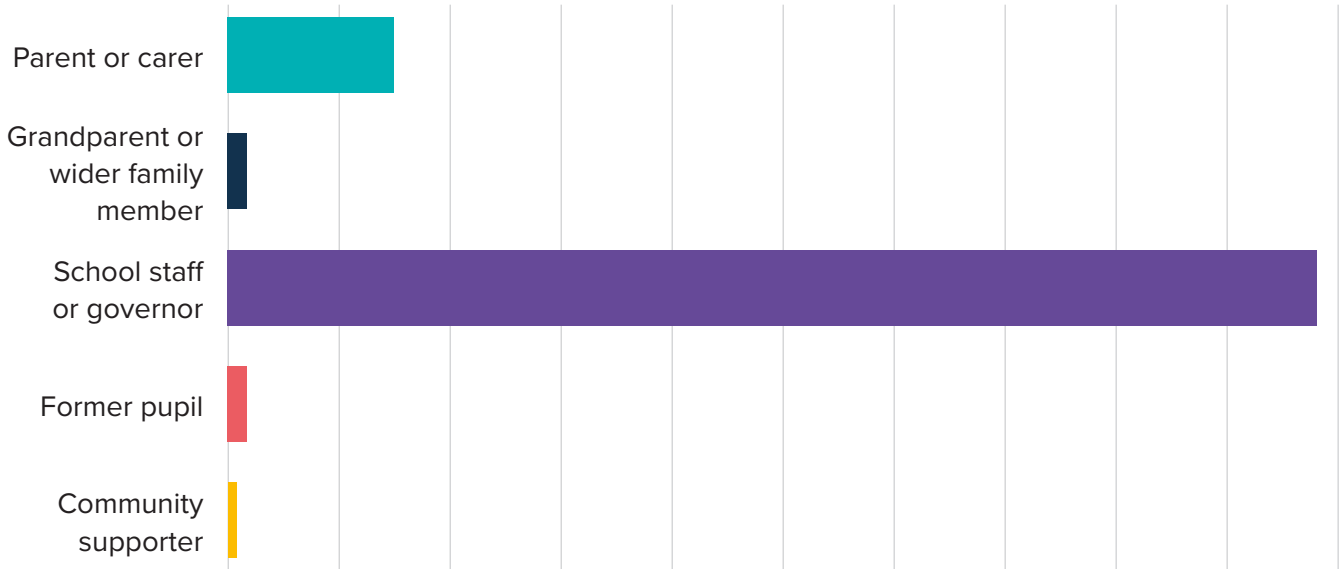
Appendix B: Five Key Issues from Narrative Question 2 Issues the Petition Should Address

1. Teacher workload has become structurally unrealistic and is driving staff out of the profession.
2. Pay and retention challenges affect both teachers and support staff across all settings.
3. SEND inclusion without adequate provision is failing pupils, staff, and families.
4. Schools are compensating for the collapse of wider social services and community support.
5. Crumbling infrastructure, ICT pressures, and compliance costs are draining core education budgets.



Q1.

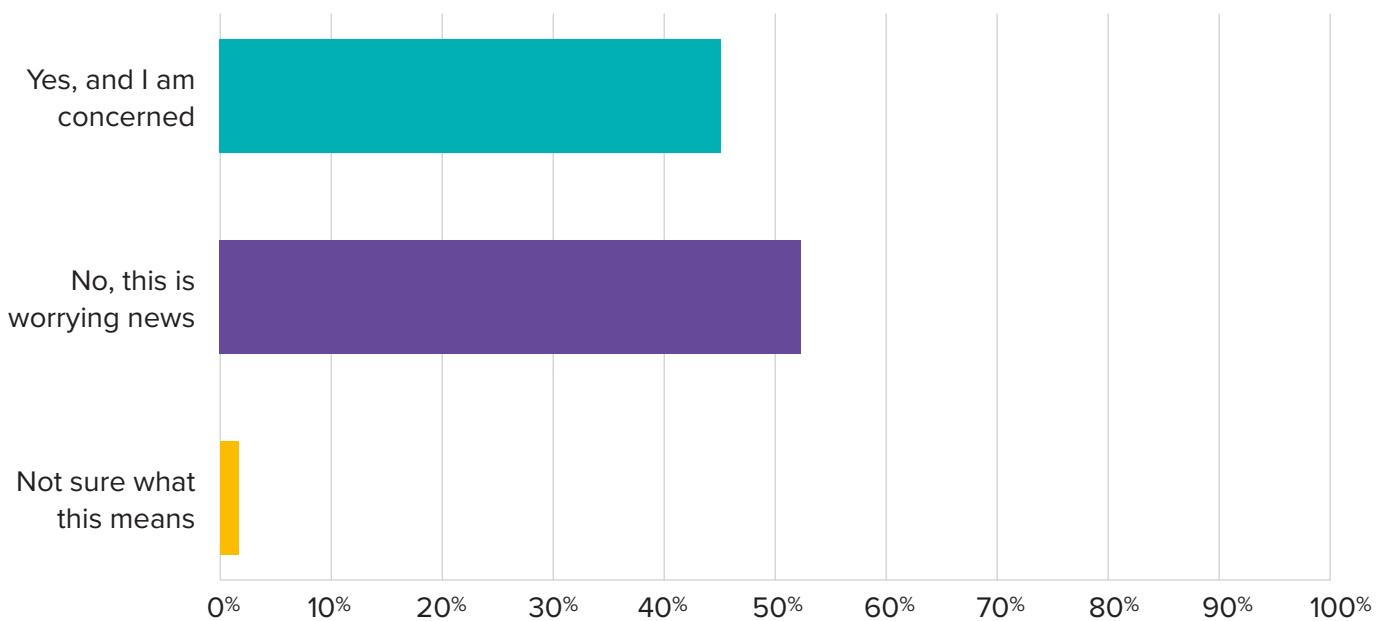
**How are you connected to a local school?
(please tick all that apply)**



Answered: 269 | Skipped: 1

Q2.

Before today, were you aware that per-pupil funding is forecast to be 4.9% lower in real terms by 2028/29?

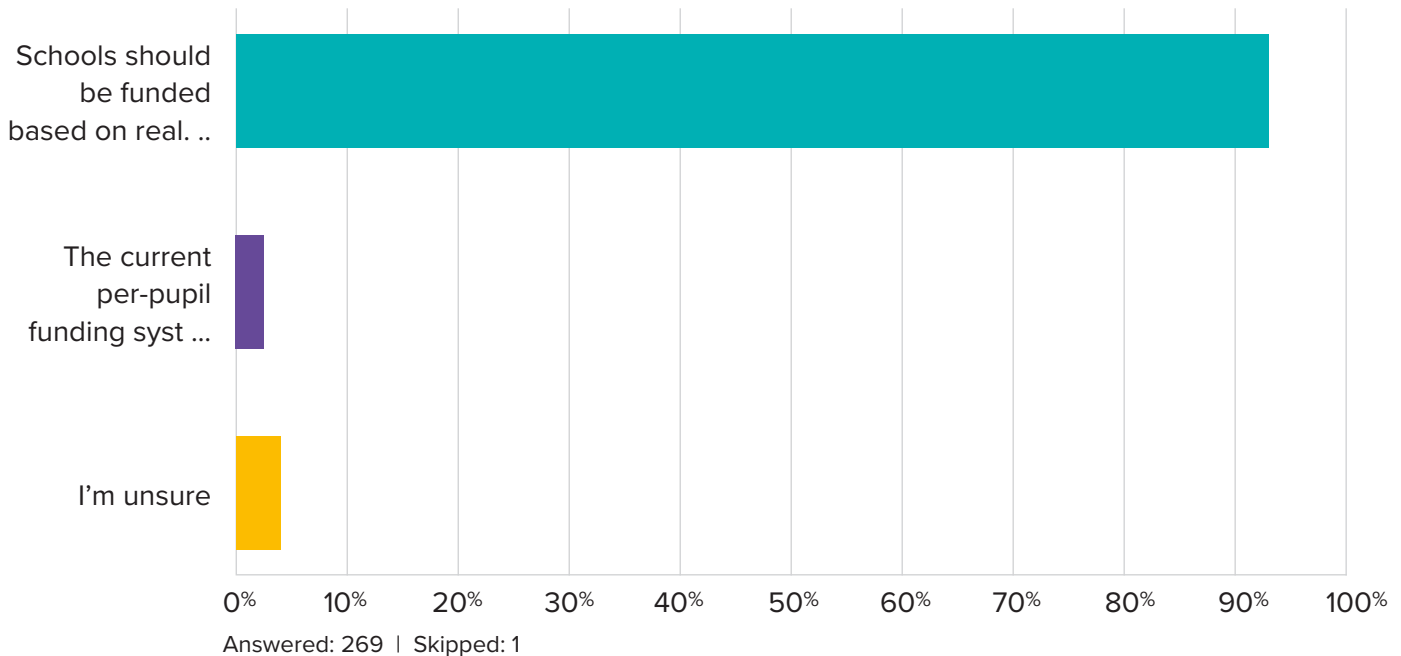


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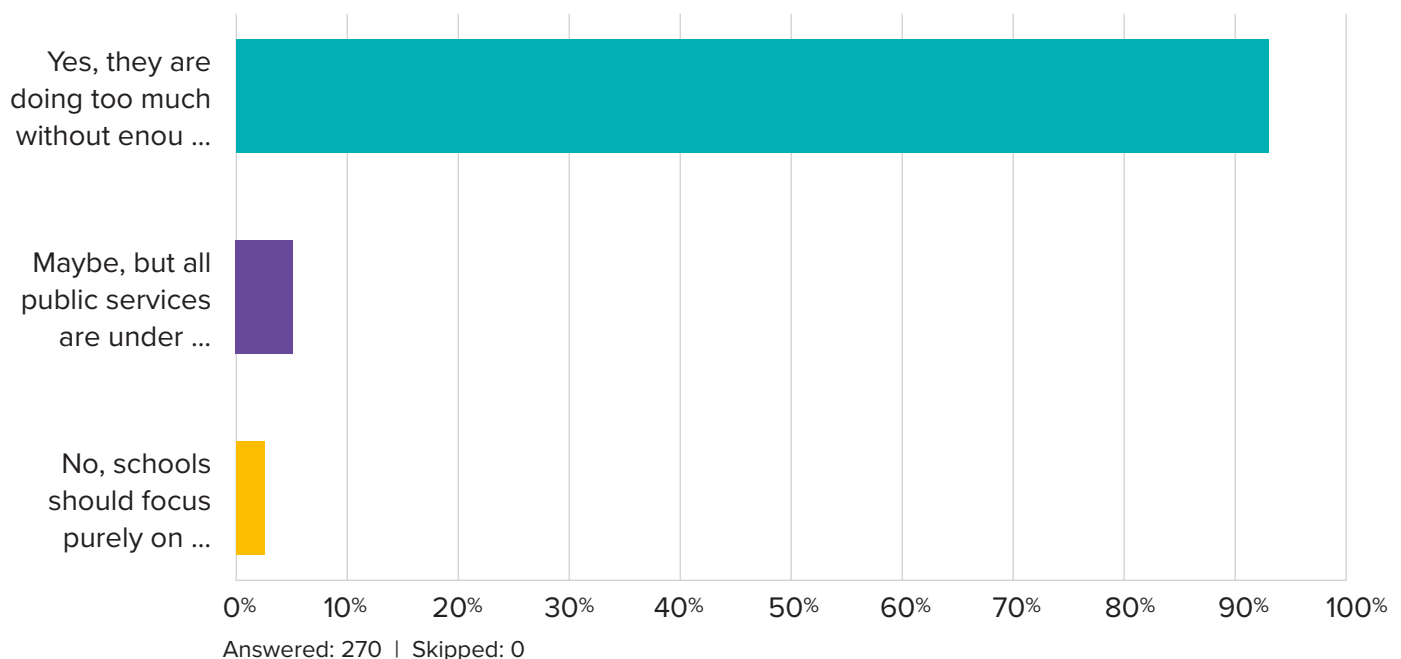
Q3.

Schools are currently funded per pupil rather than based on their real operating costs. Which statement best reflects your view?



Q4.

Schools now provide wide support beyond teaching, including mental health support, safeguarding, food aid and family guidance. Do you believe schools should receive dedicated funding for these services?



Q5.

Would you support a call to government to reform school funding so that:

